

Collaboration - bringing people with diverse thoughts together is her strength

more difficult than she had anticipated. "I did not feel equipped," she recalls. The confidence she had built through years of academic and extracurricular rigour suddenly felt fragile. Chip design, tools, systems, and even basics like Unix were unfamiliar, and she worried about coping. It was more than a technical challenge; it was an identity shift.

Rather than hiding her struggles, she did something that would become a recurring pattern in her life: she asked for help. Her professor, TJR, had a solution: "Teach my students VLSI design." What began as an act of survival soon became a revelation. Her days settled into a rhythm of studying, teaching, and learning all over again. "The students liked me and my teaching style and professors would chide me, assuming I was a student walking around the corridors during class hours," she says. Looking back, she realised she was not simply building her technical foundation; she was discovering how she learned best: by stepping into uncertainty and growing through it with others. In parallel, having already stepped into significant family responsibilities soon after her mother's passing, she learned to balance and multitask. Those experiences quietly reshaped the way she thought about both success and leadership.

As a first-time leader, she stepped into a team where many of the engineers knew technically more than she did. Once again, she faced a question she could not answer through expertise alone: How do I add value? Until then, much of her life had been spent asking whether she knew enough. Leadership required a different question: How can I support and build trust with the team? That shift in perspective moved her focus away from proving herself and towards enabling others. In many ways, the leader she became was forged during those years, through learning how to navigate uncertainty, carry responsibility, and help people succeed even when she herself was still figuring things out.

Leadership through awareness

Over time, Malini consistently found that ideas became clearer through conversation and collaboration. "When I was with people, I could think better. Solve better," she says.

That insight gradually shaped her career and leadership philosophy. Rather than focusing on authority, she became interested in connecting the dots between the technical problem at hand and what motivated people. One experience stayed with her: one of her exceptionally smart engineers was repeatedly sacrificing family time because releases were scheduled late on Friday evenings. Instead of accepting it as a fixed reality, she asked a simple question: Why Friday? The release cycle was moved to Wednesday, and the checks were scripted up. Customers received better deliverables earlier, and the engineer got his evenings back.

Her own mistakes reinforced the same belief. Early in her career, she once presented an entire team project herself because she happened to be the strongest communicator. Only later did she realise what had been lost. "You may be the best at something," she reflects, "but bringing people along matters more in the long run."

Years spent in Canada added another dimension to that understanding. Surrounded by a different culture, she gradually became more aware and comfortable with who she was, while adopting the best aspects of that culture.

Today, that clarity sits at the heart of her leadership. She believes influence is more powerful than authority, empathy more enduring than control, and listening more valuable than having all the answers. "If you can influence someone through an idea," she says, "you'll always be more successful than telling them what to do."

As she puts it, "Awareness doesn't make decisions easier. It makes them clearer."

Beyond one role: Building a career across disciplines

One reason Malini's leadership perspective feels unusually broad is that her career rarely followed a straight line. Over the years, she moved across multiple functions, technologies, and responsibilities, often stepping into unfamiliar territory long before she felt completely ready. Her early years at National Semiconductor exposed her to test-chip and digital design flows, providing a strong technical foundation. From there, she moved into corporate application engineering roles at Synopsys and Rambus, working closely with customers and leveraging that technical foundation. As her career progressed, she took on leadership responsibilities in application engineering and development